

University of Connecticut (Stamford)

Laughing in the Face of Authoritarianism...or not?

Political Satire, Institutional Critique and the Power of Dramatic Realism in *Andor*

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Abstract

This paper examines how *Star Wars* has traditionally depicted social and political themes through spectacle-driven allegory, emphasizing mythic scale and visual excess. It then situates Tony Gilroy's *Andor* within this framework, arguing that the series shifts toward a grounded portrayal of authoritarian practices and the gradual formation of resurgent movements. Drawing on scholarship surrounding political satire, this paper considers how humor has historically enabled institutional critique through what is called a "dual processing effect," while also questioning its viability in today's political climate, where reality more often mirrors absurdity. In contrast, *Andor*'s dramatic realism produces emotional proximity to political themes and the consequences of political violence, while also offering an alternative mode of engagement. Ultimately, the paper suggests that genre plays a critical role in shaping political resonance in contemporary film and television.

Keywords: authoritarianism; resurgent and resistance movements; political satire; dual-processing effect; dramatic realism; institutional critique; genre; political resonance

LAUGHING IN THE FACE OF AUTHORITARIANISM...OR NOT?

POLITICAL SATIRE, INSTITUTIONAL CRITIQUE AND THE POWER OF DRAMATIC REALISM IN ANDOR

TOPIC

AUTHORITARIANISM & RESURGENT MOVEMENTS

How power is maintained,
normalized, and resisted
within systems of control.

DIGITAL MEDIA OBJECT

ANDOR (2022 – 2025)

A Star Wars series that
grounds political conflict
in everyday life under
the Galactic Empire.

ABSTRACT

This paper examines how Star Wars
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KEY TAKEAWAYS



Star Wars traditionally relies
on spectacle and allegory to
engage with political themes.



Andor uses grounded,
procedural storytelling to
depict authoritarianism
and resistance.



Political satire once critiqued
power through humor and
distance, but its impact
weakens when reality
becomes absurd.



Dramatic realism creates
emotional proximity and
moral urgency.



Genre shapes how audiences
connect with and respond
to political narratives.

The Disney+ series *Andor* (2022 – 2025), a political drama created by Tony Gilroy, occupies a distinctive position within the larger *Star Wars* franchise. Set in the years leading up to *Rogue One: A Star Wars Story* (2016), the series follows the gradual political awakening of Cassian Andor (Diego Luna) as authoritarian control tightens across the galaxy. While *Star Wars* has long depicted imperial power through spectacle and mythic confrontation, *Andor* redirects attention toward the prosaic mechanics of authoritarian rule and the slow formation of organized resistance in its opposition – a shift in tone that invites closer consideration of how film genre shapes the way that political themes are received.

This paper situates *Andor* alongside the historical tradition of political satire as the dominant mode of institutional critique in order to assess how genre influences audience engagement with political themes in today's media and political landscape. To develop this comparison, the paper first contextualizes *Andor* within the broader narrative of the original *Star Wars* trilogy and its prequel, *Rogue One*. It then examines how the series portrays authoritarian practices and the gradual formation of resistance movements through relevant scholarly frameworks. After positioning political satire as a longstanding mode of institutional critique, the paper then considers how satire has historically shaped public engagement with political power before turning to the limitations of comedic distance within today's political climate. And lastly, it evaluates how *Andor's* dramatic realism reshapes the emotional and political resonance of its themes potentially offering an alternative avenue for such institutional critique.

Politics, in a Galaxy, Far, Far, Away: Franchise Context

To understand *Andor's* place within the franchise, it is necessary to first recognize that *Star Wars* has always functioned as a political allegory. George Lucas has stated that the original films were shaped in part by the Vietnam War and the political climate of the Nixon era,

particularly his interest in how democracies transform into dictatorships (Beckwith). From its inception, then, *Star Wars* has been concerned with political themes like authoritarian rule, anti-authoritarian movements, and the collapse of democratic institutions.

The original trilogy – *A New Hope* (1977), *The Empire Strikes Back* (1980), and *Return of the Jedi* (1983) – depicts a galaxy ruled by the First Galactic Empire, an authoritarian regime that emerged from the collapse of the previous democratic Republic. Under Emperor Palpatine (Ian McDiarmid), institutions are dismantled, civil liberties are curtailed, and power becomes centralized through aggressive military enforcement. Stormtroopers patrol occupied systems, and Darth Vader (James Earl Jones), his red lightsaber-wielding apprentice and enforcer, serves as the visible embodiment of imperial terror (see fig. 1). The narrative largely follows characters like Luke Skywalker (Mark Hamill), Princess Leia (Carrie Fisher), and their allies as they resist this regime.

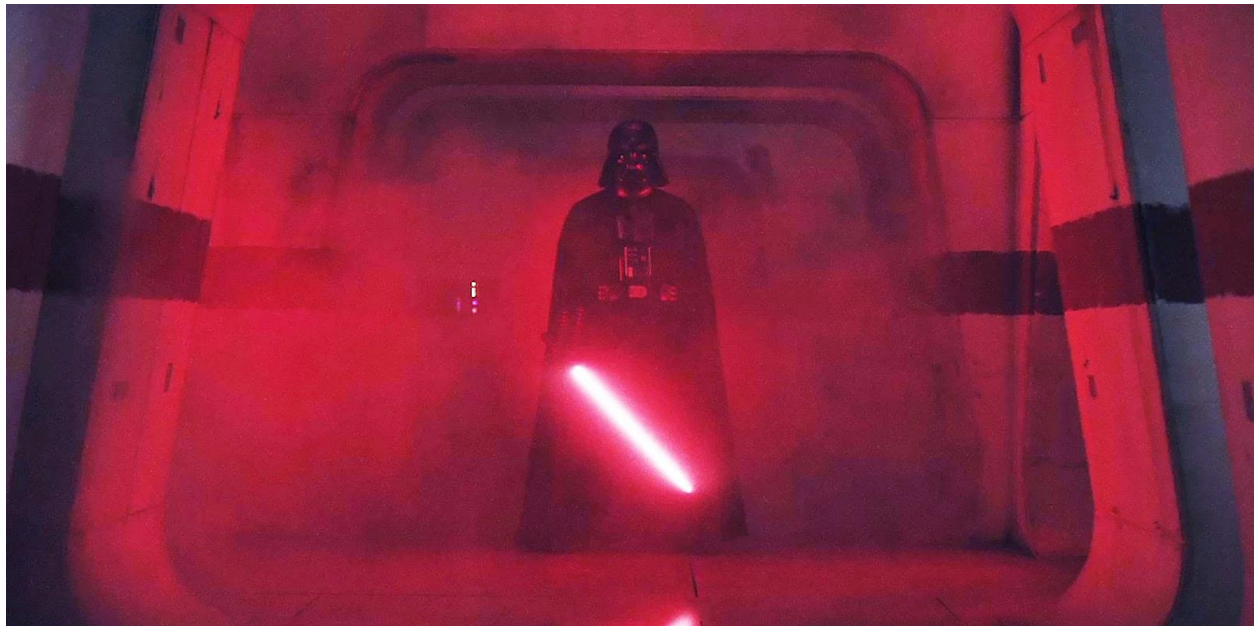


Fig. 1. Darth Vader, the Empire's enforcer of authority and physical embodiment of fear, in *Rogue One: A Star Wars Story*. Voiced by James Earl Jones. Directed by Gareth Edwards, 2016.

Image from Bold Entrance, <https://boldentrance.com/darth-vader-in-rogue-one-the-secrets-behind-that-crazy-corridor-scene/>.

Partially owing to its expansive science fiction world-building, *Star Wars* has traditionally presented these political tensions through spectacle and outrageousness. In *A New Hope*, the Empire destroys Princess Leia's home planet, Alderaan, after she refuses to reveal the location of the Rebel Alliance's stronghold to Darth Vader. The weapon used to do so – the Death Star – is *not exactly* subtle (see fig. 2). It's an enormous, planet-killing machine, and its use reinforces both the scale and threat of imperial dominance. That commitment to spectacle is further expanded in *The Empire Strikes Back*, where the story's protagonists are forced to flee across the frozen plains of the planet Hoth while avoiding 75-foot mechanical war machines known as AT-ATs (see fig. 3). By the trilogy's final installment, *Return of the Jedi*, the Empire reveals it has been constructing a second planet-destroying weapon after the Rebels successfully destroyed the first. Across all three films, political allegory is consistently conveyed through visual excess and catastrophic destruction.

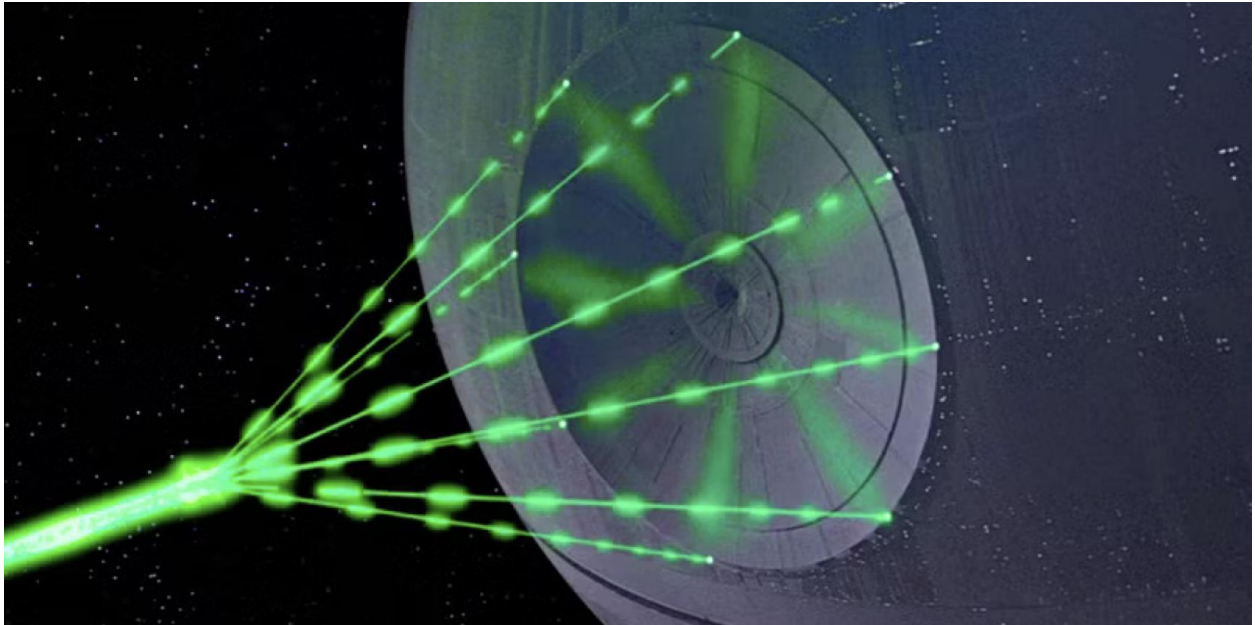


Fig. 2. The Death Star firing upon Alderaan in *Star Wars: Episode IV – A New Hope*. Directed by George Lucas, 1977. Image from ScreenRant, <https://screenrant.com/star-wars-alderaan-death-star-destruction-luthen-sadder/>



Fig. 3. Imperial AT-AT walkers advancing across the planet Hoth in *Star Wars: Episode V – The Empire Strikes Back*. Directed by Irvin Kershner, 1980. Image from StarWars.com, <https://www.starwars.com/databank/at-at-walker>

Rogue One marks a shift within the franchise by moving away from the Skywalker family and toward lesser-known, and in some cases entirely new, figures within the rebellion. Set immediately before *A New Hope*, the film follows Cassian Andor and a small coalition of insurgents tasked with stealing the Death Star plans. Those plans ultimately allow the Rebel Alliance to identify a structural weakness in the weapon and destroy it in the events of *A New Hope*. In this way, *Rogue One* narrows the scope of rebellion efforts in the universe and foregrounds the individuals whose actions make the original saga's more visible triumphs possible.

Andor, set approximately five years before *Rogue One*, further narrows this scope and traces the earlier political and moral trajectory of Cassian Andor, a man surviving at the margins of imperial society, motivated primarily by self-preservation. Across two seasons, the story expands beyond Cassian to include figures such as Luthen Rael (Stellan Skarsgård), Mon Mothma (Genevieve O'Reilly), Saw Gerrera (Forest Whitaker), Dedra Meero (Denise Gough), Syril Karn (Kyle Soller), and Karis Nemik (Alex Lawther). By the end of its second season, *Andor* positions these political actors within an increasingly interconnected political landscape that converges with the insurgency depicted in *Rogue One*.

Authoritarian Practices and the Normalization of Control

The political system in which the characters in *Andor* operate can be more precisely understood through existing scholarly frameworks of authoritarianism. Social and behavioral sciences professor Mariles Glasius defines authoritarianism not as a fixed regime type, but instead in terms of “authoritarian practices,” concrete actions that restrict institutional accountability, silence opposition, and weaken pluralism within political systems (Glasius). Central to this framework is the normalization of such practices in society. Authoritarian power endures not only through dramatic shows of force, but through the repeated, everyday application of surveillance, bureaucracy, and punitive enforcement.

Andor illustrates this dynamic through its depiction of the Imperial Security Bureau (or the ISB), the Empire's centralized intelligence and enforcement apparatus, tasked with monitoring dissent, expanding jurisdiction of the Empire, and disciplining perceived threats across the galaxy. The ISB is portrayed as a competitive administrative body, complete with strategic briefings and data-driven assessments of risk. Within this structure, characters such as Dedra Meero and Syril Karn are motivated not by theatrical villainy but by ambition and

institutional recognition, and these professional aspirations are inseparable from the expansion of imperial control, as well as the suppression of resistance. Historical scholarship on Nazi Germany similarly notes that the Gestapo was staffed not only by ideological extremists but also by trained police officials and career professionals embedded within bureaucratic hierarchies (United States Holocaust Memorial Museum). In this sense, repression becomes routinized and bureaucratically sustained rather than achieved through spectacular means.

The carceral arc of the series further reinforces this normalization. Cassian's arrest and imprisonment on Narkina 5 reveal a system structured around repetition and endless labour. The prison operates with mechanical efficiency: shifts rotate; sentences extend arbitrarily; inmates are recycled through a process designed to erase individuality. The horror of this environment does not derive from spectacle, but instead, from monotony. Thus, by grounding authoritarianism in paperwork, procedure, and institutional compliance, *Andor* reframes imperial power not as something sustained by singular catastrophic events, but by the steady participation of individuals within an apparatus of control.

Resurgent Movements Under Constraints

Authoritarian systems, however, do not operate uncontested. In "The Origins of Anti-Authoritarianism," Nina Witoszek argues that anti-authoritarian revolutions often originate in "small groups and individuals" who "cultivate...shared moral frameworks before broader [mobilization] becomes possible" (Witoszek). Resistance, in this account, does not emerge fully formed but develops through dispersed actors who gradually recognize a common cause. Under conditions of repression, these actors must operate cautiously, often in isolation, building networks slowly before coordination becomes viable. Elizabeth Ann Stein's study of Brazil's military regime between the '60s and the '80s further demonstrates how such movements survive

under constraint. Stein explains that dissident leaders monitored press censorship as a “barometer” of state tolerance, strategically timing demonstrations based on how far the regime appeared willing to go (Stein). Resistance, therefore, is shaped not only by moral conviction but by tactical awareness of institutional limits.

These insights illuminate the structure of rebellion in *Andor*. Luthen Rael and his assistant Kleya Marki (Elizabeth Dulau) operate through a covert communications network that connects otherwise disorganized cells in the early stages of rebellious efforts. Using code transmissions and carefully calibrated exchanges, such as “I have friends everywhere,” they coordinate action without exposing the full scope of their operations. Mon Mothma represents another form of resistance, working within the Imperial Senate while discreetly maneuvering finances and probing the system alongside politically duplicitous colleagues. Even as she maintains a public persona of compliance, she sustains dissent beneath the surface. Saw Gerrera leads a militant faction that remains ideologically committed yet organizationally fragmented, skeptical of coordination even while contributing to the destabilization of imperial authority, often through violent means. None of these figures initially function as a unified movement. Instead, they represent parallel and often disconnected efforts shaped by risk, secrecy, and distrust.

Cassian’s trajectory is central to this evolution as well. He begins the series largely apolitical, shaped by early experiences of imperial encroachment on his home world Kanari and later by repeated confrontations with authority. As an adult, he survives through evasion and self-interest, frequently at odds with the law, but not yet committed to rebellion. The Aldhani heist (Season 1: Episodes 4–6) marks a turning point in his journey, exposing him to organized resistance and to the moral language that accompanies it. His imprisonment on Narkina 5

radicalizes him further, transforming survival into defiance. By the time of the Ghorman massacre in Season 2, where imperial repression escalates into public atrocity, Cassian's reluctance gives way to conviction. His eventual alignment with Luthen's network is not instantaneous but cumulative, reflecting the gradual process through which lived experience, tactical coordination, and moral articulation converge. By the end of the second season, these dispersed efforts begin to align, bringing the narrative into closer proximity with the insurgency depicted in *Rogue One*.

Satire as a Historical Mode of Institutional Critique

Throughout history, institutional critique has frequently been conducted through comedy, and more specifically through political satire. Political satire uses humor, irony, and exaggeration to expose institutional hypocrisy while providing audiences with emotional distance from the severity of the critique. By rendering the logic of authority absurd, political satire destabilizes institutional power and exposes structural flaws while remaining digestible to broad audiences.

Mark Boukes, in his study, "At Odds: Laughing and Thinking? The Appreciation, Processing, and Persuasiveness of Political Satire," argues that satire combines entertainment and persuasion in ways that encourage simultaneous cognitive and emotional engagement (Boukes). Humor lowers defensive resistance while embedding critique within a comedic frame, producing what Boukes identifies as a "dual-processing effect." This process has become foundational to how cinematic and televisual narratives have conducted institutional critique while remaining broadly accessible to audiences.

This dynamic can be observed across a range of cinematic examples. Films such as *The Candidate* (1972) depict electoral politics as a process shaped less by ideology than by image construction and strategic messaging. *Wag the Dog* (1997) dramatizes media manipulation and

warfare to expose the performative nature of political spectacle. Even works like *V for Vendetta* (2005), though more overtly dystopian, employ stylized exaggeration and symbolic theatrics to critique authoritarian governance.

Andor: A Different Kind of Star Wars Story

From Spectacle to Proximity

If the original *Star Wars* trilogy expressed political tension through visual excess and catastrophic scale, *Andor* adopts a markedly different approach. Rather than amplifying authoritarian power through technological enormity or mythic confrontation, the series narrows its lens, foregrounding procedure, bureaucracy, and the lived consequences of state violence. Its critique is not filtered through irony or exaggeration, but through immersion.

The Ghorman massacre in *Andor's* second season provides one of the clearest examples of this shift. Over the course of the season, tensions of the planet Ghorman steadily escalated. The empire had increased its presence on the planet under the pretense of maintaining order while quietly advancing extraction initiatives connected to the construction of the first Death Star. As imperial resource demands intensified and local autonomy eroded, Ghorman citizens began organizing public demonstrations in Palmo Plaza, the planet's central square. These protests were civic in nature, calling attention to economic exploitation and political repression. Imperial authorities, however, reframed this dissent as insurgency. What began as public protest was increasingly characterized as coordinated rebellion, creating a justification for military intervention (Wookieepedia – The Star Wars Fandom).

On the day of the massacre, the escalation is depicted as procedural rather than explosive. Civilians gather in the square. Imperial troops form rigid lines and slowly constrict the space.

Bodies press together. Commands are barked by Stormtroopers. The tension builds through proximity rather than spectacle (see fig. 4). When blaster fire eventually erupts, it is sudden and indiscriminate. People fall in plain sight. Panic fractures the plaza. A desperate transmission captures the horror: “We are under siege...The Imperial murder of Ghorman has begun... Hundreds lay dead in Palmo Plaza...This is murder!” (*Andor*).



Fig. 4. Tensions build between Imperial forces and Ghorman citizens in Palmo Plaza. The Ghorman Massacre in *Andor*, Season 2, Episode 8, “Who Are You?”. Directed by Janus Metz, 2025. Image from Gizmodo, <https://gizmodo.com/andor-wanted-its-massacre-to-do-more-than-just-fill-a-star-wars-lore-gap-2000615065>

Sound Design and the Social Relevance of Andor

The sequence’s emotional force derives not only from its visual framing but from its sound design as well. For much of the massacre, there is no swelling score to cue heroism or catharsis. Instead, the soundscape is dominated by blaster fire and sustained, indiscriminate

screaming. The absence of non-diegetic music during the height of the violence prevents the audience from retreating; they must endure the horror alongside the series' characters. At several moments, as well, the audio shifts into a disorienting distortion similar to the ringing effect often used in cinema to simulate a character's temporary hearing loss after an explosion. This contributes to destabilizing the viewer's perception and mirrors the chaos unfolding onscreen. By withholding music for much of this sequence, the episode effectively emphasizes a commitment to creating an immersive, visceral experience. The violence in Episode 8, "Who Are You?", is not framed symbolically; its power lies in its proximity to the horror with which it depicts. In doing so, it forces the audience to confront issues like state-sponsored violence without the distancing mechanisms that have historically characterized much of the franchise.

For many viewers and critics, this sequence resonated beyond the boundaries of science fiction. An NBC News article described the series as feeling "more relevant than ever," noting that audiences frequently pointed to its parallels with contemporary political conditions (Hamedy). While Tony Gilroy has not directly suggested that *Andor* functions as a direct allegory of any single real-world conflict, the depiction of militarized suppression, reframed protest, and state-sanctioned violence has drawn comparisons to the experiences of Palestinian civilians under Israeli occupation. The series' refusal to provide emotional distance intensifies this resonance and invites its audience to more critically confront political themes. It is precisely this confrontation that invites reconsideration of how institutional critique functions today.

Satire in an Age of Absurdity

It is also worth exploring how the effectiveness of political satire as a powerful mode of institutional critique, in the contemporary media and political landscape increasingly depends on a perceptible gap between political reality and the exaggeration used to expose or critique it. This

tension is articulated by comedian Conan O'Brien who reflected in a recent interview with *The New Yorker Radio Hour* on why he has largely stopped making jokes about Donald Trump. He explains that "there's a lot that's so bombastic and so outrageous and so unprecedented...I don't know how this is funny." He adds that if he invents something absurd – "like Trump saying he's an alien from another planet" – it often feels less shocking than what has already occurred in real life (O'Brien via *The New Yorker Radio Hour*). O'Brien's observation reinforces the idea that satire's critical force is largely dependent on the distance between reality and absurdity. And in today's political climate, where political reality appears indistinguishable at times from parody, satire may have become inadequate or insufficient as a tool of critique.

Agency in Andor: Nemik's Manifesto

If the Ghorman massacre immerses the viewer in the consequences of authoritarian power, the finale of Season 2 provides language for responding to it. In Episode 12, "Jedha, Kyber, Erso," the series returns to Karis Nemik's manifesto – first introduced during the Aldhani heist:

"There will be times when the struggle seems impossible. I know this already. Alone, unsure, dwarfed by the scale of the enemy. Remember this. Freedom is a pure idea. It occurs spontaneously and without instruction. Random acts of insurrection are occurring constantly throughout the galaxy. There are whole armies, battalions that have no idea that they've already enlisted in the cause. Remember that the frontier of the Rebellion is everywhere. And even the smallest act of insurrection pushes our lines forward. And then remember this. The Imperial need for control is so desperate because it is so unnatural. Tyranny requires constant effort. It breaks, it leaks. Authority is brittle. Oppression is the mask of fear. Remember that. And know this, the day will come when all these

skirmishes and battles, these moments of defiance will have flooded the banks of the Empire's authority and then there will be one too many. One single thing will break the siege. Remember this. Try.” (*Andor*, Season 2, Episode 12, 26:11–40:00).

As the series closes, the manifesto functions as both ideological consolidation within the story and as the emotional crescendo for the audience. Its declarative language is paired with a montage of familiar characters stepping into the next stages of their incremental but consequential journeys. Cassian accepts the mission that will carry him toward Galen Erso and the events of *Rogue One*, and the once-fragmented resistance appears to be a newly formed Rebel Alliance. In combining articulation with visible progression, the manifesto redistributes agency outward, inviting the audience to critically engage with the series' themes one last time. Ending the series in this way – especially after the raw and immersive depiction of authoritarian rule – caps off a cohesive political narrative.

Andor's Reception and its Participatory Potential

The effectiveness of this approach is reflected in the series' reception with critics and general audiences. According to IMDbPRO, *Andor* has won five Primetime Emmy Awards, with an additional 26 wins and 133 nominations. Episodes such as “Who Are You?” and “Welcome to the Rebellion” opened to 9.8 and 9.9 ratings respectively, making them among the highest-rated episodes in *Star Wars* history. On Rotten Tomatoes, the series holds a 96% critic score for Season 1 and 97% for Season 2. Beyond aggregate scores, YouTube video essays, podcasts, and sustained social media discussions have frequently positioned *Andor* as one of the most politically mature and critically engaging entries in the franchise.

Srđan Mladenov Jovanović argues that political satire can function as a catalyst for “participatory democracy and active citizenship,” suggesting that humor lowers barriers to

engagement and encourages citizens to critically evaluate power structures. His claim is specific to satire as a communicative form, and while there is not yet definitive scholarship measuring whether *Andor* directly increases civic participation by nature of its dramatical medium, its circulation through digital spaces, especially with younger audiences, suggests that dramatic storytelling may similarly expand political awareness.

Discussion

Rather than offering a definitive answer about which genre is “most effective” for purposes of institutional critique, this paper’s findings suggest that effectiveness depends on what, exactly, critique is expected to do in a given media and political environment. Political satire remains historically valuable, and Boukes’ dual processing effect helps explain why satire has endured across film and television as a medium that persuades while entertaining. Jovanović’s research further positions satire as capable of supporting participatory democratic habits by prompting audiences to evaluate power structures with less resistance. At the same time, the contemporary political landscape complicates reliance on the gap between reality and absurdity. Conan O’Brien’s discussion about refraining from making Donald Trump jokes because he is “not funny anymore” is particularly relevant in this case. His observation highlights a cultural shift in comedy, where exaggeration becomes largely insufficient. This does not eliminate satire’s function absolutely, but it certainly raises the question of whether other genres may be better positioned to generate moral urgency.

In this context, *Andor* offers a complementary model of institutional critique grounded in dramatic realism. Across the series, authoritarianism is depicted less as a single spectacle event and more as an accumulation of practices that normalize control, culminating in moments like the Ghorman massacre that refuse to put distance between the audience and emotionally charged

political themes. This immersion is followed by Nemik's manifesto, which provides articulation after confrontation, pairing declarative language with visible character progression, and redistributing a sense of agency outward. If satire historically opens critical space through humor, *Andor* suggests that immersion and moral urgency can generate a different, but equally consequential, form of engagement.

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